RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

Can We Grasp Olam HaBa?

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 2

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, continued: the three approaches to aggadah, and what Olam HaBa is

Shiur: Part 2 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 9 September 2025 (before Rosh Hashanah)

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.

Recap

Five mistaken views of the ultimate reward: **Gan Eden** (and Gehinom); **Mashiach's utopia** (food growing on trees); **resurrection** (eat, drink, be merry); **this world**, as in **Bechukotai** (*if you keep My mitzvot… rain, land*); and **all combined**. Their shared traits: **crude and physical**, and **all well supported**, from explicit verses (the fourth) to many Rabbinic statements (the first).

What no one discusses: Olam HaBa, and how everything else fits around it. Instead: *will I rise clothed?*

The parable: the less mature, the cruder the reward: **sweets → clothes → money → fame**. All ***she-lo lishmah***. **The ideal: במצותיו חפץ מאד**, loving the mitzvot, not their reward. **We do the truth because it's true.**

Why doesn't the Torah mention reward in Olam HaBa? (A question every Rishon discusses; Monday night's class started on it yesterday.) **For the Rambam it's simple: the Torah promises no reward, physical or spiritual, because reward isn't why you do mitzvot.** The blessings and curses in this week's parashah are **aids** to serving Hashem, or **obstacles** to it.

Three Ways to Read the Sages' Aggadah

Before Olam HaBa, one more introduction, because **every mistaken view cites aggadah**.

Group 1: everything literal (the majority)

> **הם מאמינים אותם כפשוטם, ואין סוברים בהן פירוש נסתר בשום פנים, והנמנעות כולם אצלם מחויבות המציאות.**

"Most of what I've seen, read and heard." They take every aggadah **literally**, with **no hidden meaning**, so **impossibilities become necessities**.

to **strip**, as in the Shabbat labour *mafshit*, **skinning** an animal. "Strip ,**להפשיט** comes from **פשט** ".it down, and **that's all there is**

The Moreh's three categories: impossible (the sun setting in the east), **possible** (rain next week), **necessary** (the sun rising in the east). Group 1 turns the **impossible** into the **necessary**, "because the Sages said it."

Why? They never developed, **and no teacher ever woke them up** to ask *perhaps there's something deeper?* Tell their beliefs **to ordinary people, let alone the wise**, and they'd be astonished anyone could believe them.

> **ויש להצטער על סכלותם, לפי שהם מכבדים ומנשאים החכמים כפי דעתם, והם משפילים אותם בתכלית השפלות.**

"It's sad." They think they're **honouring** the Sages by believing every word, **and they're degrading them utterly**, making them look like fools. "**How many times do we see this?**"

> **וחי השם, כי הכת הזאת מאבדים הדרת התורה ומאפילים זהרה. By God's life: this group destroys the Torah's glory and darkens its light.** The Torah promises the nations will say **רק עם חכם ונבון הגוי הגדול הזה**; these make them say **"a foolish, silly little nation".**

Who's to blame? The preachers

> **ורוב מה שעושים זה הדרשנים**, who explain to the masses what they don't understand. **מי יתן החרש תחרישון** (Iyov): if only they'd **keep quiet**! **Or at least say: *we don't understand what the Sages meant here.***

"Preaching the aggadot of Berachot and Perek Helek word for word": e.g. **"Hashem wears tefillin"** (Berachot), or the strange **dream** interpretations, without even saying *there's a deeper meaning I may not understand*.

Rav Shilat's insight: it's **the same problem** as the five views. Read the Sages **stripped to the surface**, and the reward is just **the surface**: wine flowing in Gan Eden, **and nothing beyond.**

The Ben Ish Chai's proof

The **Ben Ish Chai** ("a great kabbalist, with interesting *shitot*") brings, in the name of **the Rambam's son**, a proof from **Eruvin 63a**:

A student ruled **in front of his teacher**, Rabbi Eliezer, who said to his wife: *I'll be surprised if he lives out the year. Are you a prophet? No, but I've been taught: one who rules before his teacher is liable to death.* He died. Rabbah bar bar Chanah, citing Rabbi Yochanan: **his name was Yehudah ben Guria**. Why name him and his father? **שלא תאמר משל היה**: **so you won't say it was a parable.**

The Ben Ish Chai: *a great and powerful proof* that **the Talmud's stories are generally parable**. If even this unmiraculous story needed names to show it really happened, **how much more** the wondrous ones, like **Rabbah bar bar Chanah's tales** in Bava Batra. "**This shuts the mouths of those who mock our Sages.**"

Who agreed with the Rambam? Ibn Ezra (introduction to the Torah), the **Kuzari**, the **Meiri**. **Some Tosafists** took aggadah literally.

Rav Yaakov Emden's criticism: "*I heard* that in the **Spanish Inquisition** the simple Jews gave their lives, while the Rambam-ist philosophers converted": *don't mock the simple.* "Whether it's historically true, I don't know. **Two approaches**: some Sages were more sympathetic; **the Rambam wasn't.**"

Rav Chaim Brisker: "A *nebach apikoros* is also an *apikoros*." I'm sorry you're a fool, but it's still your problem.

Group 2: literal, therefore ridiculous

They too read only the surface, **and conclude the Sages were fools.** They mock, considering themselves **wiser**: often those who style themselves **physicians** and **astrologers**, "**wise in their own eyes, sharp, philosophers.**"

והם סכלים יותר מן הכת הראשונה... והיא כת ארורה. More foolish than the first group, a cursed group: they attack great men of proven wisdom. **If they understood how wisdom must be written for the masses, they'd see the Sages *were* wise.**

"Group 1 he pities. **Group 2 makes him angry.**"

Group 3: there's always something deeper

והם, חי השם, מעטים עד מאד, עד שאין ראוי לקרוא אותם כת, אלא כמו שיאמר לשמש מין.

So few, "by God's life," they barely count as a group: as one wouldn't speak of "the species of sun."

They've seen, in a **few scattered** statements, how **profound** the Sages were, and so understand:

- the Sages **don't speak nonsense**;

- their words have **a revealed side and a hidden side**;

- every **impossible** statement is **riddle and parable**, **the way of the great sages**.

Proofs:

- **Shlomo** opens Mishlei: **להבין משל ומליצה, דברי חכמים וחידתם**. A ***chidah*** means the hidden, not the plain: **אחודה נא לכם חידה** (Shimshon).

- **Shir HaShirim**: "a very romantic, erotic love story," yet **a parable** for something much deeper.

- **The Sages themselves** turn verses into parables (Berachot 18b):

- **Benayahu ben Yehoyada הכה את שני אריאל מואב**: "smote two lions"? **The two Temples.**

- **ירד והכה את הארי בתוך הבור**: "struck the lion in the pit"? **He mastered Vayikra**, which sits **"in the middle of" the Torah.**

- **David's מי ישקני מים מבור בית לחם**: a **pressing halachic question**.

- **Iyov**: some say **משל היה**. **Yechezkel's dead**: some say **משל היה**.

"**If the Sages read verses as parables, why fear reading the Sages' words as parables?**"

"Leave now"

ואם אתה המעיין מאחת משתי הכתות הראשונות, אל תשגיח בדברי. If you're in group 1 or 2, stop reading. It won't help you; **you'll hate it.**

Light food. One used to **bad, heavy food** can't enjoy **light, wholesome** food. "Once you live healthily you look at people eating rubbish: *how do they eat that?* And they look at you: *how can you not enjoy Coke, this pizza?*" Like Israel and the manna, **הלחם הקלקל**: degraded, or **light, so easy to digest**. "They want heavy meat and fish; **they can't appreciate the delicacy**."

But if you're group 3: when a statement seems far-fetched, **stop, think, know it's a riddle and parable**, **and go to bed troubled by it**, searching for its sense. **Then read my book, and it will shine for you.**

Then why is the Rambam so hard on group 1?

The Sages wrote simply **on purpose**, for children and the masses (Introduction to the Mishnah). Not everyone can be wise; in Hilchot Teshuvah we said not everyone reaches the highest levels (**Todd**). So why fault the simple?

The answer: "**It's fine to be a simpleton** and read *Hashem wears tefillin* or **Batya's arm grew long** and take it at face value, **as long as you know there's a deeper meaning you don't yet understand.** *For now I take it simply; one day I'll grow.* **Then you're group 3.**"

"**Group 1 is when that's your *shitah***: when you insist the surface is all, and **get angry** when someone explains it otherwise: *Chazal said X, how dare you!* **How can it be a grievance that I explain the Sages in a way that brings them *more* glory?** That's the problem." *(So the Tosafists who held it literally?* "**That's the group.**")

Olam HaBa

The blind can't perceive colours, **the deaf can't perceive sounds**, a **eunuch** can't perceive physical desire. **So bodies can't perceive the pleasures of the soul.**

(Correct editions say **תאוות הביאה**, not the cruder word: "**the Rambam would never use that word.**")

And just as fish don't know the element of fire, since they exist in **its opposite, water**, **so in this physical world we can't know the delight of the spiritual world.**

Why add the fish? Rav Shilat: a blind man **lives among** colours; the fish's **whole environment** is the **opposite** of fire. Olam HaBa is **diametrically opposed** to our entire physical existence.

All we know is **physical pleasure**: food, drink, intimacy. Anything else **we don't recognise** at first thought, **only after great investigation**.

"This bothered me": earlier, *can't* grasp it; here, *can, after great study.* "**Levels.** After great analysis, as we're doing, we grasp it **conceptually**. Never really."

The difference

Physical pleasures	Spiritual pleasures
Inferior, and they end	**Constant and eternal**
	No relation, no comparison at all

The angels, stars and spheres (the Rambam believed they have **awareness**; **Rav Saadia didn't, and Rav Saadia was seemingly right**) have **no bodily pleasure**, yet **constant delight** in **knowing the Creator**. **So we, purified and elevated after death**, won't want bodily pleasures:

Like a king. Like a great king who wouldn't want to give up his kingdom to go back to playing ball with the children, as he did before he reigned, back when he couldn't tell the two apart. "**How did I ever behave like that?** You know those moments."

A taste, even here

Even in this world, we choose **non-physical** goods over physical:

We sacrifice physical pleasure for...
Honour and status: we toil for wealth and titles largely **for recognition**, "**not tangible**"
Revenge: people give up sleep and money to get even, "unfortunately we see a lot"
Avoiding disgrace: many shun the greatest bodily temptation **for fear of shame**
A good name

"**Look how feeble we are.** In a few weeks, **Yom Kippur**: *have an easy fast!* **24 hours** without food is so hard. **And yet** we give up physical cravings for non-tangible things." **How much more so** in the spiritual world, where our souls **know the Creator** as the higher beings do: a delight that **can't be divided, described or compared**.

מה רב טובך אשר צפנת ליראיך (Tehillim 31). **I can't tell you what it is.**

"Their crowns on their heads"

העולם הבא אין בו לא אכילה ולא שתיה ולא רחיצה ולא סיכה ולא תשמיש המטה, אלא צדיקים יושבים ועטרותיהם בראשיהם ונהנים מזיו השכינה (Berachot 17a).

Phrase	The Rambam
עטרותיהם בראשיהם	the soul endures **through what it has understood**. "**The השארות הנפש בקיום המושכל: true soul is a person's intellectual identity**": **the knower and the known are one**, as the philosophers proved
נהנים מזיו השכינה	Those souls **delight in what they grasp of the truth of the Creator**, as the *Chayot HaKodesh* do

The goal, and the ultimate loss

הנה כי הטובה והתכלית האחרון הוא להגיע לחברה העליונה הזאת: to reach this exalted society, the soul enduring **endlessly**, sustained by the Creator who is the cause of its existence. **The greatest good, beyond comparison**: how can **the eternal** compare to **what ends למען ייטב? לך והארכת ימים: "in the world that is wholly long."**

והרעה השלמה והנקמה הגדולה היא שתכרת הנפש ותאבד: the soul is cut off and lost. That's **karet הכרת תכרת: cut off in this world, cut off in the next**. Versus **והיתה נפש אדני צרורה בצרור החיים**. One who chose bodily pleasure and **despised the truth** "remains **mere matter, cut off**."

כל הנביאים כלם לא נתנבאו אלא לימות המשיח, אבל העולם הבא עין לא ראתה אלהים זולתך. The prophets spoke only of Mashiach's days; Olam HaBa, no eye has seen.

"We'll never fully comprehend it **till the day we die**. When we get there, we'll experience it. Just as **the unhealthy can't comprehend health**."

Before the Yamim Noraim

"If only we could spend **a few moments** on Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur thinking about this, rather than only *the book of life, Hashem give me this and that*. **I say it every year because I'm saying it to myself.** It's fine to pray for a good year, **but let that not be the focus.**"

The Ramchal (as far as I remember): **זכרנו לחיים** and **מי כמוך... זוכר יצוריו ברחמים לחיים**: plain **life**. Then **וכתוב לחיים טובים** and **בספר חיים, ברכה ושלום**. "**Once *life* needs an adjective, it's physical.** The first two ask for **life itself**: **a life with Hashem, a taste of Olam HaBa now.** *Who will I be this year? Will I grow, be closer to Hashem, more perfect morally and intellectually?*"

A participant: "This makes it attainable. Otherwise it's scales in the sky, begging, **and no lasting change**; Yom Kippur ends, *the magic's done*." "**Exactly.** So people **make it physical: take on one *kabbalah***. One man told me his Yom Kippur *kabbalah* was **saying Birkat HaMazon from the book**. Lovely, **but look at the big picture.**" *"It's more comfortable to escape the truth."* "**Correct**, rather than address **the core issues**."

Summary

1. **The Torah promises no reward**: mitzvot aren't done for one.
2. **Three readings of aggadah:**
3. **literal** (the majority, "honouring" the Sages while **degrading** them, blamed on **preachers**);
4. **literal, therefore foolish** (a "**cursed**" group, more foolish than the first);
5. **always deeper** (so few they're like "the species of sun").

The Ben Ish Chai's proof (Yehudah ben Guria). **Parables in Tanach** (Shir HaShirim, Benayahu's lions).

3. **It's fine to be simple** if you know **there's more**. The fault is **insisting** there isn't.

4. **Olam HaBa can't be perceived by the physical**: the blind and colours, **the fish and fire**. We sense its reality only in our willingness to trade the physical for honour or a good name.

5. **"Crowns on their heads"** = the soul's **intellectual identity**, enduring; **"the radiance of the Shechinah"** = **knowing Hashem**. Eternal and incomparable. **Karet** = the soul **cut off**.

6. **Before Rosh Hashanah:** pray for **חיים**, not just **חיים טובים**.

Coming Up

Next week: how **Gan Eden, Gehinom, Mashiach and techiyat hametim** fit around **Olam HaBa**, and then the **13 Principles** begin. *(No halachah shiur this Wednesday or Thursday.)*

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